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YOUTHS FOR GREEN ACTION KENYA (YGAKE) BUNGOMA COUNTY

200,000 TREE PLANTING REPORT

Project theme: Future in a Million Trees



ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

The Youths for Green Action Kenya NGO acknowledges that the success of the MtELGON200000Tree campaign would not have been possible without the support of various individuals and teams. The organization extends its immense gratitude to its donors: German Imaging Technologies (GIT), Naivas Supermarket, Victoria Furniture, and individual philanthropists, for their financial contributions to the project. Special thanks to; Mr Faisal Husain, Uday Bhasin, Ruchir Punjani, and Dr Rich Khatib whose financial contribution helped YGAK achieve this project.

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INTRODUCTION

Discussions surrounding environmental conservation and rehabilitation often seem disconnected from engaging the youth and local indigenous communities, who are the custodians of our natural forests and biodiversity. Youths for Green Action Kenya (YGAK), a fully youth-led NGO, focuses directly on the grassroots level where environmental advocacy and climate action are most urgently needed. Amid economic complexities and adverse weather effects such as prolonged droughts and excessive rainfall, we need constant reminders of our connection to and dependence on nature. This connection is crucial, as a healthy planet is directly linked to human health and welfare, ensuring a sustainable future for upcoming generations. Who better to take care of sustainability than the youth?

Trees play a vital role in this effort by mitigating the impacts of climate change through carbon sequestration, acting as significant carbon sinks. Additionally, collaborating with local indigenous communities and other stakeholders, both in government and the private sector, ensures environmental sustainability while addressing the needs of the local agrarian economy.

From May 13th to 19th, 2024, Youths for Green Action Kenya continued with the “Future in a Million Trees” planting project, aimed at restoring biodiversity in the Kaberwa forest in Bungoma County. Driven by the values of unity and cooperation, these youth embarked on a mission to plant 200,000 trees in the Kaberwa forest, an area that once thrived with diverse flora and fauna before being devastated by unsustainable timber harvesting, charcoal burning, and human settlement. This initiative exemplifies how youth can contribute significantly to environmental sustainability and foster a greener economy amid the climate crisis.

By directly involving the youth and local communities in such projects, YGAK not only addresses immediate environmental issues but also empowers these groups to become stewards of their own natural resources. This comprehensive approach underscores the importance of grassroots participation in global environmental efforts, highlighting that sustainable development is most effective when it includes those most directly affected by environmental degradation.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

SECURING A GREENER TOMORRO: 200,000 TREES PLANTED FOR A RENEWED MOUNT ELGON FOREST

Mount Elgon Forest, a 19,000-acre natural treasure, has been neglected for too long. This vital resource nourishes sixteen rivers, shelters diverse wildlife, and acts as a water catchment area for Kenya's four major water towers. Sadly, over 1,200 acres have become degraded. To combat this, Youths for Green Action Kenya partnered with Kaberwa Forest Station, one of four stations tasked with protecting the forest. Together, we embarked on an ambitious project to plant 200,000 tree seedlings between May 13th and 19th, 2024. This initiative aimed to restore 124 acres of the degraded 350 acres targeted by the forest station.

The project aimed to significantly enhance forest cover across hundreds of acres within the Mount Elgon forest boundaries. By reintroducing native tree species, it sought to reinstate critical habitats for the forest's diverse flora and fauna populations, including endangered species like elephants, which have seen their habitats shrink.

In the long run, the project anticipates various benefits, including soil stabilization to prevent erosion, enhancement of air quality and carbon sequestration, augmentation of rainfall and restoration of groundwater levels, and provision of a renewable supply of forest products to support local livelihoods. The restoration of Mount Elgon's forest health and biodiversity is expected to boost the region's economic potential through eco-tourism. Moreover, reforestation serves as a crucial measure against climate change by reinstating a significant ecological carbon sink.

Over 300 volunteers, including 126 members from Youths for Green Action Kenya chapters, Kaberwa community members, and students from Kibuk Girls Secondary School, Kibuk Primary School, and Kaberwa Primary School, collaborated throughout the week. The well-coordinated effort involved dedicated teams planting trees in designated blocks i.e Chepkungur, 2K, 2L, Mtoni Mbili, and Bosnia. This project's success wouldn't have been possible without the invaluable support of our sponsors. We extend our deepest gratitude to our patron, Dr. Sassan Khatib Shahidi, founder and CEO of German

Imaging Technologies, for his vision and leadership. Special recognition goes to Ahad Ali, the Kenya Country Manager for GIT, for leading the project despite logistical challenges. We also acknowledge Mr. Francis Ngari (IT Head) and Jackline Chepkoech (Environment and Social Governance Specialist) of Naivas Supermarket for their pivotal role in securing financial backing. Finally, we thank Mr. Amar Shah, founder and CEO of Victoria Furnitures, for his generous contribution to sustainability efforts. A heartfelt thank you to all our partners, including the Kenya Forest Service, Kenya Wildlife Service, Masinde Muliro University, and the National Government Administration Organ (NGAO). Your collaboration was indispensable to the project's success.

The ambitious goal of planting 200,000 trees transcends mere numbers. Each seedling symbolizes a crucial step towards restoring forest health. These trees will not only reclaim degraded land but also offer a myriad of benefits. This project exemplifies the potential when the private sector, local communities, and government unite. By pooling resources, expertise, and enthusiasm, we can forge a more sustainable future for ourselves and future generations.

Project Overview

Project Name	Youths for Green Action Kenya Mount Elgon Forest Restoration: 200,000 Trees		
Project Patrons/Sponsors	Youths for Green Action Kenya, German Imaging Technologies, Naivas ,Victoria Furnitures Limited.		
Project Partners	Bungoma County Government, Kenya Forest Service, Kenya Wildlife Service, Masinde Muliro University of Science and Technology, Kaberwa Community Forest Association,		
Project Manager/Organizer	Youths for Green Action Kenya- NGO		
Start Date	13/05/2024	Completion Date	18/05/2024

Project Objectives

The Project had three main objectives namely:

1. **Biodiversity Conservation:** The project aims to enhance biodiversity by restoring degraded areas within the Mount Elgon Forest through the planting of native tree species. By reintroducing trees to the ecosystem, the project seeks to create habitats for diverse flora and fauna, including endangered species, thereby promoting ecosystem resilience and sustainability.
2. **Ecosystem Restoration:** The primary objective is to contribute to the restoration of the Mount Elgon Forest ecosystem by addressing deforestation and land degradation. Through the planting of 200,000 trees, the project seeks to combat soil erosion, improve water retention, and mitigate the impacts of climate change, ultimately restoring the health and functionality of the forest ecosystem.
3. **Community Engagement and Livelihood Improvement:** The project aims to involve local communities in tree planting activities, providing them with training and resources to participate actively in forest restoration efforts. By engaging communities in sustainable land management practices and agroforestry initiatives, the project seeks to improve livelihoods, enhance food security, and foster a sense of ownership and stewardship of the forest among local residents.



Mt ELGON 200,000 TREES PROJECT HIGHLIGHT

- **Engaged 126 student volunteers:** The MtELGON200000Trees campaign brought together 126 volunteers from various universities across the country, including Egerton University, Masinde Muliro University of Science & Technology, Technical University of Kenya, Mount Kenya University, Jomo Kenyatta University of Agriculture & Technology, Multimedia University, Presbyterian University of East Africa, Kabarak University, Chuka University, and Dedan Kimathi University of Science and Technology.
- **Engaged over 150 Kaberwa community members in the project.** The local Community members, led by the Community Forest Association (CFA) members, joined the cause.
- **Collaborative partnership** with donors from different companies such as German Imaging Technologies (GIT), Victoria Furniture Kenya, Naivas Supermarket, and individual philanthropists.
- **Partnerships with government institutions** including Kenya Forest Service, Kenya Wildlife Service, Bungoma County Government, and the Ministry of Environment Kenya were established.
- Successfully **planted 200,000 trees**, meeting our set target.
- Achieved all project objectives, including **biodiversity conservation, ecosystem restoration, and community engagement.**

Project Opening Ceremony

The official opening of the 7-day tree planting campaign was conducted on 13th May 2023. The event was graced by different partners from higher learning institutions, government officials and donors. In attendance was:

- *Dr. Khatib Sassan, founder and CEO of German Imaging Technologies (GIT)-Dubai,*
- *Prof. Alice Ndiema (Registrar, Planning Research and Innovation also representing the DVC Planning Research & Innovation-MMUST),*
- *Mr. Josphat Kipyator, Deputy County Commissioner Kapsokwony Sub – county*
- *Mr. Godwin Ndege, Chairperson Kaberwa Community Forest Association.*
- *Dr. James Owuor (Chairperson Greening Initiative-MMUST),*
- *Mr. Oscar Waswa (Assistant Registrar Student Affairs Department MMUST),*
- *Mr. Godfrey Opana (Kaberwa Forest Station Manager)*
- *Mr. Pulei (local community Chief) & Mr. James Ole Nakola (County Youth Coordinator)*
- *YGAK Board officials led by Ms Wangeci Mwangi and*
- *YGAK secretariat led by Mr. Denis Asiya (CEO)*

TREE PLANTING (200,000)

Youths for Green Action Kenya, NGO, was allocated 52. 46 HA / 129. 63 acres of land in Kaberwa forest, to push its regeneration and conservation agenda. The organization was specifically allocated plots at Chepkungurur, Darfur, Bosnia, 2K, 2L, Mtoni Mbili and Ngam Plots in the Kaberwa forest land. Volunteers engaged in planting trees every morning with a target of at least 200 tree seedlings per person per day which the volunteers embraced so well with different donors happily joining in the activity. The sloppy terrain in the forest did not hinder the volunteers who were excitedly determined to accomplish their daily targets.



**MT ELGON TREE PLANTING PROJECT WITH NUMBER OF TREE SEEDLINGS
GROWN PER ALLOCATED PLOT**

PLOT NAME	PERIMETER	AREA	GPS COORDINATES	TREE POPULATION
Ngam 1	13446.61M	60996M ²	0° 52' 26" N 34° 40' 22" E	16144
Ngam 2	13446.61m	30842.1M ²	0° 52' 23" N 34° 40' 30" E	12757
Mtoni Mbili	762.38M	34079.9M ²	0° 52' 49" N 34° 40' 21" E	12677
2L PLOT 1	1668.01M	55982.4M ²	0° 52' 54" N 34° 40' 10" E	19196
2L PLOT 2	112.56M	292.53M ²	0° 52' 54" N 34° 40' 10" E	292
2L PLOT 3	993.94M	18863.24M ²	0° 52' 54" N 34° 40' 10" E	5865
2K PLOT 1	300.03M	4191.97M ²	0° 52' 58" N 34° 40' 23" E	370
2K PLOT 2	1069.0M	33212.16M ²	0° 52' 58" N 34° 40' 23" E	3480
CEREMON Y GROUNDS	303.36M	4698.2M ²	0° 53' 9" N 34° 40' 12" E	627
BOSNIA PLOT 1	964.07M	27756.41M ²	0° 23' 16" N 34° 51' 16" E	8222
BOSNIA PLOT 2	1056.75M	33494.91M ²	0° 23' 16" N 34° 51' 16" E	14171
BOSNIA PLOT 3	798.6M	20047.72M ²	0° 23' 16" N 34° 51' 16" E	16808
DARFUR	1827.18M	91831M ²	0° 52' 46" N 34° 39' 52" E	25548
CHEPKUNGURUR	927.52M	10.83 HA	0° 52' 54" N 34° 40' 10" E	19530
TOTAL	40195	52.46HA		155, 687

YGAK Statement on Strategic Adjustments for Successful Implementation of the 200,000 Trees

Due to unforeseen logistical challenges, YGAK was unable to complete the planting of 200,000 trees at a single site, Kaberwa Forest Station. We have, however, implemented a new strategy to ensure the remaining 45,000 trees are planted effectively. Over the next one and a half months, these trees will be planted in batches of 15,000. The planting will take place in allocated spaces around Mt. Elgon and in collaboration with primary and secondary schools in the identified areas. Thank you for your continued support and understanding as we work towards our environmental conservation goals.

MASINDE MULIRO UNIVERSITY REHABILITATES CHEMORIR RIVER WATERSOURCE

Alongside the main event, Masinde Muliro University of Science and Technology launched an initiative to adopt the Chemorir River water source, aiming to conserve indigenous biodiversity through a bamboo afforestation program. This important endeavour was spearheaded by the acting Vice Chancellor, Prof. Charles Mutai. The bamboo afforestation program is expected to play a significant role in preserving the ecological balance of the area, enhancing water quality, and providing a sustainable habitat for various species. Prof. Mutai's leadership and commitment to environmental conservation underscore the university's dedication to promoting sustainable practices and protecting natural resources for future generations.

CAREER GUIDANCE AND MENTORSHIP FROM DONORS AND PATRON

The volunteers were engaged in career guidance and mentorship sessions led by the organization's patron, Dr. Sassan Khatib, and GIT-Kenya's country manager, Mr. Ahad. These sessions were designed to provide invaluable insights and practical advice to the volunteers, many of whom are at crucial stages in their educational and professional journeys.

During the interactive sessions, Dr. Khatib and Mr. Ahad shared their extensive experiences and knowledge, offering a unique perspective on navigating the complexities of the job market. They discussed various career paths, the importance of building a strong professional network, and strategies for personal and professional development. Volunteers were encouraged to actively participate, with ample opportunities to ask questions, seek personalized advice, and share their own ideas and concerns. This open forum allowed for a dynamic exchange of information, where volunteers could learn from

both the mentors and their peers.

In addition to career-specific guidance, the mentors also addressed broader topics such as work-life balance, the importance of continuous learning, and the value of resilience and adaptability in the face of challenges. The session aimed to empower volunteers with the confidence and skills needed to successfully navigate their career paths and achieve their professional goals.

TEAM BUILDING

The phrase "*all work and no play make Jack a dull boy*" serves as a reminder that without time off from work, a person becomes bored and uninteresting. It emphasizes the importance of taking breaks and engaging in leisure activities to maintain one's mental and emotional well-being. Team-building activities, included hiking at the Kapsokwony caves and waterfall, dancing, exercising, playing games, and a game drive at Mt. Elgon National Park. These activities were designed to foster bonding among the volunteers. These sessions aimed to help volunteers get to know each other, strengthen their abilities, acknowledge and work on their weaknesses, and ultimately boost their motivation and productivity. By engaging in these activities, volunteers had the chance to interact, learn from one another, and develop mutual appreciation of mother nature.



FOCUS GROUP DISCUSSIONS

As members of the youthful generation in the 21st century, the volunteers face numerous challenges arising from the socio-cultural and economic dynamics of daily life. To address these issues, the project program included open-ended focused group discussions (FGDs) where volunteers could openly discuss the challenges they encountered. Each FGD group consisted of 12 volunteers and was led by a moderator. The groups were randomly selected to include volunteers from diverse regions, socio-economic backgrounds, career paths, and universities.

These FGDs aimed to gather in-depth information about volunteers' attitudes, beliefs, experiences, and opinions on a range of topics, including environmental conservation, mental health, culture, entrepreneurship, technology, gender, social justice, and career development. Each group focused on specific topics assigned to them.

The discussions were conducted in a semi-structured format, where the moderator had a list of guiding questions but allowed the conversation to flow naturally. Moderators encouraged group members to share their thoughts and experiences and to engage with each other's comments, fostering a rich and dynamic exchange of ideas.



A Thriving Ecosystem, A Thriving Community: Mt. Elgon's Remarkable Transformation

The recent planting of 200,000 trees and restoring 124 acres in Mt. Elgon Forest was not only a victory for environmental conservation and climate change action but also a foundation for a healthier, more prosperous community. Through the government's visionary Plantation Establishment and Livelihood Improvement Scheme (PLEMIS), members of the Mt. Elgon community will directly benefit from the project's success. PLEMIS allocates plots of the restored forest approximately 0.5 acres each, with 124 acres restored it translates to benefiting 250 households in Mt. Elgon Community. These plots, where the newly planted seedlings thrive, become a source of both livelihood and environmental stewardship.



Here's how this innovative scheme doubles the project's impact:

- **Food Security:** Farmers will cultivate these plots while nurturing the young trees. This "Trees First, Farming Follows" approach ensures both forest restoration and food production for the 250 households. The PLEMIS allocation guarantees food security, a critical concern addressed through this project, which they were unable to execute previously due little reforestation efforts.
- **Sustainability:** With community members invested in the forest's well-being, the sustainability of the planted trees is significantly enhanced. This fosters a collaborative effort for a thriving ecosystem.

Rooted in the Past, Growing for the Future: Youths for Green Action's Collaborative Environmental Stewardship.

At Youths for Green Action Kenya, we believe that the environment and the cultures of our communities are deeply intertwined. This isn't just a nice idea, it's a core part of our mission.

We explain this by saying that the connection between cultures and the environment is intrinsic, meaning it's built-in and fundamental. Many Kenyan communities have traditions and knowledge passed down through generations that teach appreciation and respect for the land and its resources.

That's why we put the community at the heart of everything we do. We honour and integrate the existing cultural traditions and knowledge systems. This means listening to elders, learning traditional practices for land management, and incorporating them into our environmental initiatives. This approach has two big benefits:

- **Sustainability:** When projects are built on the foundation of cultural knowledge, they're more likely to be accepted and sustainable.
- **Richer understanding:** By collaborating with communities, we gain a deeper appreciation for the interconnectedness between culture and natural resource management.

Ultimately, this collaborative spirit drives positive change for future generations. By working together, we can ensure a future where strong communities and a healthy environment thrive side-by-side.

Hashtags: #climateaction #climatechange #futureinamilliontrees & #mtelgon200000trees #iamygak

WHAT WE DID DIFFERENTLY BY LEARNING FROM PAST EVENTS

Collection of plastic tubes as a waste management strategy:

Building on past experiences, we adopted a more structured waste management strategy, particularly for handling plastic tubes used during the tree planting activities. Instead of indiscriminately discarding them, we sorted the plastic tubes into two categories: those in good condition and those that were damaged. The tubes in good condition were redistributed to local communities for reuse, promoting recycling and reducing waste. Damaged tubes were responsibly incinerated at a designated central location under careful supervision to minimize environmental impact. This approach not only managed waste more effectively but also engaged the community in sustainable practices.



Organizing volunteers for increased efficiency:

To enhance the efficiency of our tree-planting efforts, we implemented a new organizational strategy for our volunteers. Volunteers were divided into specialized groups with specific roles: one group was responsible for carrying seedlings and placing them in the prepared holes, another group focused on the actual planting of the seedlings, and a final group was tasked with collecting and properly disposing of plastic waste. This division of labour ensured that each task was handled efficiently, reducing downtime and increasing the overall productivity of the planting activities.

Collaboration with local communities and school children:

Recognizing the value of community involvement and aiming to maximize our productivity within limited timeframes, we extended our engagement to include local community members and school children from two primary schools and one girl's high school. These young volunteers provided much-needed additional hands, and their enthusiasm and energy significantly boosted our ability to meet our planting targets. The inclusion of school children also served an educational purpose, instilling the importance of environmental stewardship in the younger generation.



Efficient transfer of seedlings:

To streamline the transfer of seedlings from the collection point to the planting holes, we employed a group of selected volunteers whose primary role was to handle this task. These volunteers developed an innovative method of carrying seedlings in pairs using gunny bags, which allowed them to transport more seedlings at once while conserving energy. This method proved to be highly productive, ensuring a steady supply of seedlings to the planting teams and maintaining the momentum of the tree-planting process. By learning from past events and incorporating these improvements into our operations, we were able to execute our tree-planting campaign more effectively and sustainably, ultimately enhancing our impact on environmental conservation and community involvement.



Project Monitoring and Evaluation (M&E) Plan

Objective: The M&E plan aims to comprehensively assess the implementation and outcomes of the MtELGON200000Trees project to ensure sustainability, accountability, capture lessons learned, and inform future decision-making regarding similar initiatives.

Indicators:

- Number of trees planted against survival rates
- Diversity of tree species planted
- Area of forest land restored
- Community participation rates
- Volunteer satisfaction and feedback
- Environmental impact indicators (e.g., soil erosion rates, water quality improvement)

Data Collection Methods:

- Field surveys and GPS mapping to quantify the number and species of trees planted, as well as the area of land restored.
- Interviews and focus group discussions with project participants, volunteers, and community members to assess their experiences, perceptions, and suggestions.
- Review of project documentation, including implementation plans, budgets, and progress reports.
- Environmental assessments to monitor changes in ecological indicators over time.

Data Analysis and Reporting:

- Quantitative data will be analyzed using statistical software to identify trends, patterns, and correlations.
- Qualitative data will be thematically analyzed to extract key insights and lessons learned.
- Findings will be compiled into comprehensive evaluation reports, including recommendations for future projects.
- Reports will be disseminated to project stakeholders and made publicly available to promote transparency and learning.

Statement for Sustainability:

While the MtELGON200000Trees project was a one-time initiative, its impact and legacy can endure through strategic planning, capacity building, and knowledge sharing.

1. **Legacy Building:** The project's outcomes, including the restoration of forest land and the engagement of local communities, can serve as a model for future conservation efforts in the region.
2. **Capacity Building:** By equipping community members with the skills and knowledge to sustainably manage forest resources, the project lays the foundation for ongoing environmental stewardship.
3. **Knowledge Sharing:** Lessons learned from the project, including successful strategies and challenges encountered, can be documented and shared with other organizations and stakeholders to inform future initiatives.
4. **Policy Advocacy:** The project's successes can be used to advocate for supportive policies and investments in forest conservation and restoration at the local, regional, and national levels.

While the MtELGON200000Trees project may have been a singular endeavor, its impact will resonate far beyond its duration, contributing to the long-term sustainability of Mount Elgon's forest ecosystems and the well-being of local communities.

CONCLUSION

The success of the MtELGON200000Trees project was the result of collaboration among diverse yet united individuals sharing a common vision for a sustainable future. Serving as a stepping stone for the organization, this project set new benchmarks for achieving ambitious goals in future endeavors. Despite encountering challenges during implementation, it served as a catalyst for refining our project management methodologies.

Our collaboration with local communities and schoolchildren played a pivotal role in surpassing our targets and fostering a culture of environmental stewardship and sustainability. Aligned with the Sustainable Development Goals, our organization aspires to amplify its impact, striving to shape a future admired by all.

RECOMMENDATION

1. **Enhance Public Awareness:** Invest in targeted marketing and outreach campaigns to raise awareness about YGAK's activities and mission among the general public, potential volunteers, and stakeholders. Utilize social media, community events, and partnerships with local organizations to amplify visibility and engagement.
2. **Diversify Funding Sources:** Explore avenues for diversifying funding sources to reduce reliance on a single revenue stream. This could involve seeking grants from governmental and non-governmental organizations, corporate sponsorships, crowdfunding campaigns, and individual donations. Develop a comprehensive fundraising strategy to sustain long-term financial stability.
3. **Strengthen Project Management:** Continuously evaluate and refine project management techniques based on lessons learned from past experiences. Implement robust monitoring and evaluation systems to track progress, identify challenges, and adapt strategies accordingly. Invest in training and capacity-building initiatives for staff and volunteers to enhance project execution capabilities.
4. **Forge Strategic Partnerships:** Foster strategic partnerships with governmental agencies, non-profit organizations, educational institutions, and local communities to leverage collective expertise, resources, and networks. Collaborate on joint initiatives, share best practices, and coordinate efforts to maximize impact and reach shared goals.
5. **Empower Local Communities:** Prioritize community engagement and empowerment by involving local stakeholders in project planning, implementation, and decision-making processes. Offer training, capacity-building workshops, and educational programs to equip community members with the knowledge and skills necessary for sustainable environmental management and advocacy.

6. Advocate for Policy Changes: Advocate for policy reforms and legislative measures that support environmental conservation, sustainability, and youth empowerment initiatives. Engage with policymakers, government officials, and relevant stakeholders to raise awareness about pressing environmental issues, propose evidence-based solutions, and advocate for the adoption of environmentally-friendly policies and practices.

As an organization, implementing these recommendations will enhance our effectiveness, expand our impact, and contribute towards building a more sustainable future for Kenya and beyond.

PHOTO GALLERY





Youths For Green Action Kenya Greening Schools Initiative.

1. Executive Summary

The YGAK Greening Schools Initiative will be an annual environmental sustainability project focusing on tree planting, community engagement, and environmental education. The 2024 edition saw the participation of various Primary and Secondary Schools, who became active partners in promoting sustainable practices and contributing to Kenya's Vision 2030 and the government's 15 billion trees initiative.

This report outlines the objectives, activities, and outcomes of the initiative. It highlights student and community involvement, sustainability practices, and long-term impacts on environmental conservation.

2. Introduction

The YGAK Greening Schools Initiative seeks to engage schools, students, and local communities in planting of 45, 000 tree seedlings and environmental stewardship. By collaborating with schools, we aim to foster a culture of environmental responsibility, increase biodiversity, and promote sustainable development.

This initiative is aligned with national and global efforts to address climate change, promote biodiversity, and contribute to Kenya's goal of planting 15 billion trees by 2030. It offers students hands-on experience with tree planting and sustainable practices.

3. Program Objectives.

The key objectives of the YGAK Greening Schools Initiative include:

1. **Tree Planting:** To increase the green cover by planting tree seedlings at the school and surrounding community.
2. **Environmental Education:** To educate students and staff on sustainability, renewable energy, and environmental stewardship.
3. **Community Engagement:** To involve the local community in greening activities, promoting environmental consciousness beyond the school.
4. **Support National Initiatives:** Contribute to Kenya's Vision 2030 and support the government's initiative to plant 15 billion trees.

4. Activities Undertaken

4.1 Pitting Holes.

Students, alongside school staff and volunteers, prepared the planting sites by pitting holes to ensure proper seedling establishment. This hands-on activity gave students practical experience in land preparation, a crucial step in tree planting.

4.2 Seedling Planting

YGAK provided tree seedlings that were appropriate for the local environment, ensuring their viability and sustainability. Students actively participated in the planting process, learning about the importance of afforestation and reforestation in combating climate change.

4.3 Sustainability Measures

After planting, students were tasked with taking care of the planted trees. This included watering, mulching, and protecting the young saplings from harm. The initiative emphasized long-term care to ensure the survival of the trees.

5. Support Provided by YGAK.

YGAK played a key role in ensuring the smooth implementation of the initiative by offering the following support:

1. Procurement of Seedlings: YGAK secured a variety of seedlings suitable for various schools and the ecosystem they are found within.
2. Transportation of Seedlings: Safe transportation of the seedlings to the school was organized by YGAK to avoid any damage or wastes during transit.
3. Ongoing Support: YGAK provided continuous support and guidance, including follow-up visits to monitor the growth of the trees and ensure the success of the initiative.

6. Outcomes and Impact.

6.1 Environmental Impact.

1. Number of Trees Planted: 45, 000 trees were planted, contributing to the overall target of planting 15 billion trees nationally.
2. Biodiversity: The initiative enhanced biodiversity within the school's environment, supporting local wildlife and improving air quality.
3. Water Conservation: The planted trees will contribute to water conservation efforts by reducing soil erosion and maintaining the water cycle.

6.2 Educational Impact.

Student Engagement: Students were actively involved in every stage of the tree planting process, gaining practical knowledge about environmental conservation.

Environmental Stewardship: The initiative cultivated a sense of responsibility in the students, motivating them to take an active role in preserving the environment.

6.3 Community Involvement.

Local community members were invited to participate, fostering a sense of collective responsibility and ensuring the initiative's long-term success.

7. Challenges and Lessons Learned

7.1 Challenges.

Climatic Challenges: Unpredictable weather patterns presented challenges in ensuring the planted seedlings received adequate water at the time of plantation.

Logistical Constraints: Transportation of seedlings to remote areas posed logistical challenges.

7.2 Lessons Learned.

Early Planning: Proper timing of activities, especially during the rainy season, would significantly enhance the survival rates of the planted trees.

Community Engagement: The success of the initiative depends on active community involvement and ensuring the local population understands the long-term benefits of the project.

8. Conclusion and Recommendations.

The YGAK Greening Schools Initiative was a successful endeavor that contributed to environmental sustainability and education. The initiative not only enhanced the schools green cover but also educated students on the importance of environmental conservation.

8.1 Recommendations for Future Programs.

Increase Follow-up Visits: Regular follow-ups are necessary to monitor the progress of the planted trees.

Expand Educational Workshops: Additional workshops on topics such as renewable energy and waste reduction would further enrich the program.

Encourage Long-Term Partnerships: Collaborating with local governments and environmental organizations can help expand the impact of the initiative.

9. Acknowledgments

Special appreciations go to our Donors and sponsors German Imaging Technologies for sponsoring this endeavor and ensuring its success to the later. We would like to thank the administration, staff, and students of the various Schools that participated for their enthusiastic participation. Special thanks also go to the local community members who supported this project. Finally, we express our gratitude to YGAK volunteers for their unwavering commitment to environmental conservation.

APPENDICES





YOUTHS FOR GREEN ACTION KENYA, CONCEPT NOTE INTRODUCTION

The environment has limited natural resources with fragile life-support systems, and thus, can carry limited amount of burden. However, in the quest for economic progress and welfare, it is the environment that more often, gets compromised. Wide scale environmental degradation is the consequent result of society's insatiable appetite for growth and development. There is an urgent need to balance growth and development without putting a lot of burden on environmental resources.

Youths for Green Action Kenya was thus established in 2018 to be an organization of the youth and for the youth in championing environmental conservation and help protect the environment. This organization was previously known as Youths Action Kenya NGO which was later in 2021 changed to Youths for Green Action Kenya and registered under section 10 of the Non-Governmental Organizations Co-ordination Board of Kenya. YGAK aims at capacity building youths and communities to promote environmental management and conservation. This has been achievable through engaging in programs/projects and activities that create environmental awareness and education.

The Youths for Green Action Kenya, NGO, is a wholly youth-led organization seeking to position the youths at the center of environmental action. The organization believes that the youths have the capacity to drive change with regards to climate action agenda. The organization ensures collaborative engagement with other organizations, institutions of higher learning, corporate organizations and individuals towards promoting environmental conservation.

Mission

We are dedicated to environmental improvements that foster a sustainable future and leads to social and economic empowerment in our communities.

Vision statement

We envision a clean, healthy, safe and sustainable environment in Kenya and beyond

Aim

- i. To promote conservation and sustainable use of environment
- ii. To promote the culture of community philanthropy and volunteerism among the youths

Major thematic areas

- i. Environmental education, research, awareness and outreach
- ii. Conservation leadership

Focus

Our major focus is achieving a sustainable environment by ensuring that the natural systems can continue to provide the natural resources and ecosystem services upon which the economy and society depend. We understand this is a process and we focus on approaching it from local and regional levels with emphasis on the environment.

Methodology

Focus is given to outreach projects and activities in our communities that aim at greening the environment; tree planting, solid waste management and creating environmental awareness. For all our established projects, we conduct follow up routines to ensure efficiency and long-term impacts. We empower community generated projects through partnership to ensure maximum incorporation of community players in operations. Philanthropy stands out as a main vehicle towards promoting the well-being of humanity and cultivate the spirit of one society and its ability to solve its challenges.

Impact

We have had successful projects focused on building community resilience towards addressing challenges posed by climate change. We have carried out tree planting, youth leadership workshops,

Environmental education in primary and high schools and stakeholder's meetings in the theme.

We have successfully planted over 450,000 tree seedlings in the Counties of Narok, Nakuru, Mombasa, Kakamega, Kisumu, and Bungoma within three years of partnership, and additionally in 14 other counties where YGAK volunteers undertook individual tree planting initiatives guided by YGAK, and collected over 50 tons of wastes in our different cleanup activities. Having been able to partner with different institutions, organizations and individuals, has helped us gear towards achieving our goals and objectives. The organization so far has also reached out to a million people through our activities and on our social media platforms.

Youths for Green Action Kenya is targeting to plant over 200,000 tree seedlings yearly, and making higher learning institutions in Kenya clean by collecting wastes. We anticipate to further reach out to the less fortunate individuals or groups in our society through quarterly donations. The organization targets to build strong partnership with institutions and other organizations that promotes its agenda, as well as providing guidance

SUCCESSFUL PROJECTS CONDUCTED PREVIOUSLY

1. Mombasa 35,000 Mangroves and Solid Waste Management Awareness Initiative

The Mombasa 35,000 Mangroves and Solid Waste Management Awareness Initiative aimed to restore mangroves in Mombasa County. This four-day project involved YGAK volunteers from various universities, local community members, and collaboration with government agencies, donor organizations, and media representatives. The initiative extended beyond tree planting, incorporating a cleanup activity and focused group discussions to address broader environmental and societal challenges.

The project successfully restored mangroves at Port Reitz Creek, providing coastal protection, biodiversity, and climate resilience for the communities. It also educated the local community on

mangrove conservation and solid waste management, significantly contributing to environmental awareness. Additionally, the initiative positively impacted the volunteers, enhancing their trust, communication, camaraderie, leadership, and problem-solving skills.

2. Annual August Tree Planting Challenge – 2023

The Annual August Tree Planting Challenge, initiated in 2022, continues to thrive in subsequent years with another successful campaign. This ongoing program has garnered widespread participation and is characterized by strategic planting of diverse tree species and extensive community engagement. The month-long initiative has consistently elevated tree planting efforts each year, demonstrating a steadfast dedication to environmental sustainability. In 2023, participation surged by 130% compared to the previous year, with 18 committed participants actively involved in tree planting activities. This increased participation facilitated positive relationships through mentorship and addressed immediate needs through generous donations. Notably, the number of trees planted during the challenge more than doubled, achieving a remarkable 131% increase over the previous year, with a total of 2,359 trees planted. Moreover, the deliberate implementation of planting diverse tree species resulted in a 35% increase in species variety, significantly enriching the local ecosystem. This ongoing initiative continues to strengthen community bonds and mentorship through collaborative efforts, contributing to a greener and more sustainable future.



3. Egerton Tree Planting Project - "The Future in a Million Trees" Campaign

In alignment with World Environment Day, observed on June 5, 2023, and the national commitment to enhancing tree cover, Youths for Green Action Kenya (YGAK) organized the "Future in a Million Trees" campaign at Egerton University. This event served as a platform to raise awareness and educate participants about the crucial role of youths in environmental stewardship and conservation.

The campaign achieved significant milestones. On the planting day, volunteers successfully planted 1,700 tree seedlings in the Agroforestry area of Egerton University. Additionally, 70 volunteers received training on seedling handling and management to ensure effective planting and tree growth.

The event also provided an opportunity to enlighten participants on the importance of supporting the government's efforts to increase the national tree cover. The event was supported by the Faculty of Environment and Resource Development at Egerton University and the YGAK Egerton Chapter, with participation from 70 YGAK ambassadors.

4. Narok Project (Theme: Future in A million Trees)

From May 22nd to 28th, 2023, Youths for Green Action Kenya (YGAK) successfully carried out the "Future in a Million Trees" planting project in Chebitat, Mau Forest, Narok County. The Narok100000Trees campaign attracted around 200 volunteers from various universities, 100 local community volunteers, donors from companies like German Imaging Technologies and Victoria Furniture, Mount Meru group, and partners from several government institutions and organizations such as Kenya Wildlife Service (KWS). This collaborative effort was aimed at regenerating the lost biodiversity in the region. YGAK was allocated 110 acres of land in Chebitat Forest to advance its conservation efforts, marking a significant achievement in their mission to restore and preserve the environment.

5. Mombasa Project (Theme: Action for sustainable city and community)

Conducted in 10th-14th January 2022, YGAK in partnership with the County Government of Mombasa and Egerton University carried out a community service in Bangladesh slums and Bangladesh Mangrove creek working closely with the Bangladesh elites Community Based Organizations, Linda

Mikoko Self Help Group and Big Ship Community Based Organization. Activities conducted included; clean up and sensitization of the community to promote community based environmental action, planting of 500 Mangrove trees along Bangladesh Mangrove site, capacity building workshop on climate action, and career and skills development.



6. Kakamega Project (Theme: Future in a Million Trees)

The Organization partnered with German Imaging Technologies (GIT), County Government of Kakamega, National Environment Management Authority (NEMA) and Masinde Muliro University of Science and Technology (MMUST) in an effort to improve rural, school and urban environmental conditions and to educate and empower local communities on environmental concerns. The project was carried out between 26th-29th May, 2022 with external funding from German Imaging Technologies (GIT). Trees were planted in three sub-counties; Shinyalu, Ikolomani, and Lurambi. the specific targeted sites included Shitoli Polytechnic and Kambiri Community in Shinyalu Sub-County, St Jerome Savane Polytechnic in Ikolomani and Bondeni primary in Lurambi Sub-County. A total of 10,000 tree seedlings were planted; 4000 Indigenous trees, 5700 exotic trees and 300 fruit trees.

7. World Environment Day (Theme: Only One Earth)

Youths for Green Action Kenya volunteers on 5th June 2022 joined the County Government of Nakuru Department of Environment and Natural Resources and other stakeholders in making the World Environment Day. On this day, the organization together with other partners planted 5,000 trees in Menengai forest. The celebration was graced by Nakuru county Environment Chief Officer as the guest of honor.



8. Kisumu Project

The County Government of Kisumu committed to plant 40 million tree seedlings to help achieve the national afforestation agenda of planting at least 2 billion trees by 2022. To achieve this, the organization joined the commitment by the Kisumu County government by planting a total of 1000 tree seedlings within Kisumu town between 28th-30th October 2022. The organization planted trees in various institutions including, Kenya Medical Training College- Kisumu main campus, Joyland Secondary school, Citam School Kisumu, ACK Shauri Moyo ward, and finally at The Mosque of Jesus Christ son of Mary. The organization attracted diverse partners including Kisumu County Government-environmental Department, YGAK- volunteers from Masinde Muliro University, Kenyatta university, Egerton university, the Technical University of Kenya, technical university of Mombasa, Kenya Medical Training College- Kisumu main campus, Joyland special school, Citam Kisumu, ACK shauri Moyo, and The Mosque of Jesus Christ Son of Mary.



9. Run for the Mau

This is an annual event organized by Egerton University for the rehabilitation of Njoro River. The organization partnered with the university and other cooperate organization in ensuring a commitment towards rehabilitation of the river. The organization committed to plant 1000 trees to facilitate the event which were planted on 7th April 2023.

Other activities

The organization has engaged in different capacity building activities/workshops to ensure that the volunteers are up to date with the current environmental trends. We have also been nominated to environmental champion competitions like the Hummingbird Awards where we won different tree seedlings and seed-balls to help foster our mission. Bringing the volunteers together through different occasions like climate action seminars, teambuilding activities, workshops and talks has been key to ensure that we keep up with our enthusiasm.

Glance impact

- Conducted 25 **projects**
- **Planted** over 450,000 trees in different parts of the country
- **Collaboration**- On boarded the following partners: German Imaging Technologies, Victoria Furnitures Limited, Mount Meru Gas LTD, TagDev – RUFORUM Programme, Naivas, Watu Credit, Egerton university, NEMA, County governments, Kenya Forest Services, Kenya Wildlife Service, Masinde Muliro University of Science and Technology.

- **Monitoring and Evaluation**- we monitored and evaluated the impact of the initiatives and projects carried out during the year. This we believe will help the organization understand what is working well and what can be improved to achieve its goals more effectively
- **Creation of Awareness** - The NGOs has invested its efforts on raising awareness on environmental issues among the public especially in schools. We believe this will help build support for the NGOs initiatives and increase its impact.



YGAK in Statehouse Primary School



YGAK in Akuisi Secondary School

Challenges

1. **Funding Constraints:** Securing adequate funding to support YGAK's initiatives and projects is a significant challenge. Without sufficient financial resources, the organization continues to struggle to implement its programs effectively, hindering its ability to scale up operations, conduct outreach activities, and provide necessary resources for tree planting campaigns, environmental education initiatives, and community engagement efforts.
2. **Policy and Regulatory Hurdles:** YGAK continue to encounter challenges related to navigating complex regulatory frameworks and policies governing environmental conservation and community engagement initiatives. This include bureaucratic hurdles in obtaining necessary permits for tree planting activities, compliance with environmental regulations, or challenges in advocating for policy changes that support sustainable development and conservation efforts.

Additionally, inconsistencies in enforcement or interpretation of environmental laws and regulations at the local, regional, or national levels pose obstacles to YGAK's objectives and operations.

Funding

The organization sources its funds from grants and project funds, donations and gifts, members' contribution, and income generating activities like tree seedling selling to run its activities.

Structure of administration

1. Board of Directors
2. Chief Executive Officer
3. YGAK Secretariat
4. Volunteers

Membership

Our constitution provides membership under various categories open to Youths worldwide and corporations willing to help further our Agenda. As of May 2024, the total number of registered members are 450. We are targeting to have more than 1,000 registered members. Our membership coverage is across the country (Kenya) with more than 6 higher learning education institutions, Egerton University, Jomo Kenyatta University of Science & Technology, Kenyatta University, Maasai Mara University, Masinde Muliro University of Science & Technology, Technical University of Kenya, Chuka University, Multimedia University, Dedan Kimathi University of Science and Technology and Embu University.

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